



The acropolis at Tikal, one of the greatest surviving series of ruins in the Mayan world.

IN ETHIOPIA, THE KINGDOM OF

AKSUM became one of the earliest states to **embrace Christianity** outside the Roman Empire. The Syrian Christian missionary Frumentius converted the king, Ezana (r. 320–60) to Monophysitism (a doctrine emphasizing a single nature of Christ, the divine). A letter from Constantius II to Ezana in 357 has survived, **urging Ezana to shift his allegiance to Arianism** and to replace Frumentius with an Arian bishop—evidence that the Roman emperors took seriously the religious loyalties of their neighbors. Ezana conducted military campaigns beyond his borders; an inscription speaks of



Shapur II hunts a stag

Sasanian rulers commissioned lavish silver items depicting themselves hunting wild beasts as a display of their royal power.

palace complexes set in a central “acropolis.” The Mayans developed a

hieroglyphic form of writing that survives on many of the **stelae** (carved stone slabs) they set up to commemorate important events; in Tikal the first such dated monument is from 292. The first named king of Tikal is **Siyaj Chan K’awil I**

(c. 305), and by the reign of Chak Tok Ich’aak I (r. 360–78), Tikal was by far the **largest and most powerful** of the Classic Maya cities.

The **Roman Empire** faced invasions on both its western and its eastern borders in the 340s and 350s. In the West, **the Franks**

began to push across the Rhine, and in the early 350s they overran part of the Rhine frontier, occupying some old Roman fortresses. **Caesar Julian** engaged in a series of **campaigns against the Franks** (356–59) and drove them from most of the territory they had taken.

In the East, **conflict** broke out again between the Romans and the Persians, under **Shapur II** (r. 309–79), who took advantage of the political turmoil in the Roman Empire in the 350s. In 359, Shapur II advanced farther west and **took the great Roman fortress of Amida** (modern Diyarbakir, Turkey). Other towns were captured and their populations deported to Persia, threatening the Roman position in the East.

6
SQUARE MILES
THE AREA
OF THE CITY
OF TIKAL,
c. 400

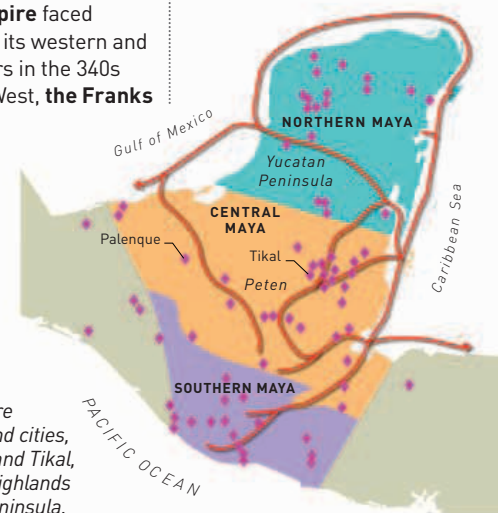
expeditions against neighboring “Gaze, then the Agame, and the Siguene,” and it seems his armies may have occupied **Meroë city** (in northern Sudan). Enriched by such conquests and the control of trade from sub-Saharan Africa and Arabia, **Aksum** would **dominate the region** until the 7th century.

The **pre-Classic Maya** kingdoms of Guatemala and Mexico underwent a collapse

some time in 200–300, with populations declining and building activity ceasing. But the region soon recovered, with the emergence of **a new phase** in Maya civilization, the Classic period (300–900), in which a series of **powerful kingdoms emerged**. Their great urban centers, such as those at Tikal (in Guatemala) and Palenque (in Mexico), are characterized by **huge pyramidal temples** and

KEY

- Northern Maya
- Central Maya
- Southern Maya
- Mayan site
- Trade route



Maya kingdoms

Classic Maya culture originated in lowland cities, such as Uaxactun and Tikal, but spread to the highlands and the Yucatán peninsula.

356 St. Antony, leader of monastic movement in Egypt and “Desert Father,” dies (born c. 251)

356 Bishop Athanasius of Alexandria **exiled** once more

356–57 Constantius II issues laws banning divination and sacrifices, and closing pagan temples

357 Church council at Sirmium issues pro-Arian creed

358 Constantius II campaigns across Danube against Quadi and Sarmatians

358 Huge earthquake devastates western Asia Minor

359 Church councils at Rimini (of bishops) and at Seleucia in Cilicia agree the **homois formula**—a compromise between Arian and orthodox Nicene Christians

359 Shapur II invades Syria and captures Amida

360 Council of Constantinople promulgates pro-Arian creed

360 Julian's troops declare him emperor in Paris